SOC 170: Population Problems (DISCUSSION)
University of Wisconsin-Madison, Spring 2026

Teaching Assistant: Hanbi Park **Email:** hanbi.park@wisc.edu

Office: 7102 Sewell Social Sciences **Office Hours:** Monday 2:20 pm – 3:20 pm (or by appointment)

Section	Time	Location
301	M 9:55 am - 10:45 am	6112 Sewell Social Sciences
302	M 11:00 am - 11:50 am	6112 Sewell Social Sciences
303	M 12:05 pm - 12:55 pm	6112 Sewell Social Sciences
304	M 1:20 pm - 2:10 pm	6112 Sewell Social Sciences

OBJECTIVE

In discussion section, you will prepare for success on exams, in future coursework, and in your future careers. The purpose of these meetings is not simply to summarize or regurgitate course content. Instead, they are designed to help you practice articulating your own perspectives to others, develop the capacity to listen carefully to and engage with others' ideas, and ultimately strengthen your social critical thinking and logical reasoning skills.

OVERALL STRUCTURE

Prior to discussion section:

You are expected to come to discussion with a strong understanding of the previous lecture and having completed the required readings. Arriving unprepared can disrupt the discussion environment for your peers and make it difficult for the group to engage in deeper, more meaningful conversation. Ultimately, consistent preparation is essential for your own academic growth in this course.

During discussion section:

Discussion Time!
Each discussion section will be structured around questions related to the lecture and assigned readings. We will begin with small-group discussions in groups of three to four students, followed by a large-group discussion.

During the small-group portion, each group will work through the discussion questions and develop key takeaways. In the large-group portion, groups will briefly share the most meaningful insights, points of debate, or remaining questions that emerged from their conversations.

If you have a course-related question you genuinely want to explore with others, you are encouraged to raise it during either the small-group or large-group discussion, as long as it is grounded in the course materials and readings. I would also like to note that covering all the questions in the section is not the ultimate goal of the section in itself. Because my goal is to make the sections a space for engaging discussions among students, I will encourage the students to discuss the materials in depth rather than simply answering the pre-established questions.

In-Class Worksheets
Occasionally, I may distribute handouts during class. In most cases, you will complete these handouts collaboratively in your group.

EXPECTATIONS

Our meetings are designed to help you better understand readings and prepare for exams, so it is essential that you complete required readings *before* we meet for discussion. I expect you to be prepared to engage with course material. You will need to do more than skim the readings. Underline, highlight, and make notes in the margins.

Do not hesitate to ask questions. There are no stupid questions, and other students may be holding onto the same ones. If you do not feel like asking a question in section, or if you think of a question outside of section, feel free to speak with me before/after our meeting, e-mail me, come see me during office hours, or post questions on Canvas.

We are all responsible for fostering a respectful and welcoming environment. Disagreements and debates are good learning opportunities, so don't hesitate to offer your perspective or opinion, and politely explain what you disagree with and why. Your classmates with similar experiences or beliefs will feel validated, and others will learn from you and reflect on how and why they agree or disagree. Share your perspective, and we'll try to find areas of agreement and understand sources of disagreement. Varied perspectives are welcome as long as they can be communicated in a respectful manner. Your words shape the room. Speak in ways that invite others in, not ways that shut them down.

I will hold myself to the same standards to which I hold you. I acknowledge that there isn't always a "correct" answer or perspective, and I want you to question or correct me if I say something you disagree with or find unclear. I will be sure to clarify or correct myself if this happens.

I will not dismiss anyone's position or opinion out of hand, but I may ask you to justify your position or relate it to course material. In cases of disagreement, I will ask questions to challenge different perspectives. When appropriate, I will share my own thoughts on an issue.

ACCOMMODATIONS

I aim to make this course accessible to all students regardless of ability. Students with McBurney accommodations must communicate with me about their accommodations and other needs within two weeks of the first section. This helps me provide the best possible experience and make all necessary accommodations. I encourage all students to discuss with me any personal situations or emergencies that may affect performance in the course.

GRADING

Your grade in section accounts for 20% of your grade for the course: 10% for attendance and 10% for Quality Participation.

- **Attendance (10%)**

Attendance is a critical part of your success in this class. I will take attendance each week, and you will not receive attendance credit if you miss more than 10 minutes of section without letting me know beforehand. You may miss one discussion section without an excuse with no effect on your grade. However, you are responsible for all information covered in section, even on days when you are absent. More than one unexcused absence will lower your attendance and participation grades. If you are late to class on a regular basis, your attendance grade may also be reduced. It is your responsibility to make up all missed work; be sure to obtain any handouts distributed in class and borrow notes from classmates. Excused absences include illness, university-approved travel, emergencies, and other extreme cases. **The best way to avoid an unexcused absence is to communicate ahead of time.** I will be reasonable and accommodating when possible and appropriate.

- **Participation (10%)**

Participation is critical to your learning and to creating a discussion section that is productive and engaging for everyone. I expect you to contribute each section in a meaningful way. This can take many forms, including making a comment during the large-group discussion, engaging actively in small-group activities, submitting notecard questions at the beginning of class, or helping move the conversation forward by asking clarifying questions.

High-quality participation is respectful and civil, grounded in the required readings and lecture material, and helps facilitate meaningful discussion. In order to contribute meaningfully, it is imperative that you come to class prepared, having completed the required readings. At the same time, your participation will not be evaluated solely on how much you speak or whether your comments are "correct." Instead, focus on thinking critically about the concepts, attempting to apply them, and engaging your peers in genuine academic exchange. This may also mean

listening attentively, giving others space to speak, and helping the group stay connected to the course material.

COVID-19: I do not encourage students to attend class when it would be unnecessarily risky to do so. For this reason, I am instituting an alternative attendance/participation policy so that students can stay home without their grade suffering. If you are showing symptoms, have been exposed to others that are sick or have tested positive, or otherwise feel that being present in class would not be responsible, you can email me before our section begins to let me know that you cannot/should not attend. By the end of the same day, you can email me a 500-word summary/analysis of one or more readings, including two discussion questions that would be interesting to raise in class. Emails received after the beginning of our usual meeting time will not be accepted and will count as an absence. If I feel that this policy is being abused for non-health purposes, I reserve the right to revoke the policy for individuals or the entire class.

OTHER (IMPORTANT) POLICIES

- **Electronics:** I expect you to use your electronic devices in a responsible way. That means using them to help you complete the work-related tasks at hand, and not using them when they inhibit your work, engagement, or learning. If you appear to be using your electronics in a distracting or irresponsible way, I may deduct participation points or revoke your right to use them.

- **Communication:** E-mail is the best way to contact me (hanbi.park@wisc.edu). I typically check my e-mail a few times a day. If I haven't responded after 48 hours, please send a follow-up. *Sending a follow-up is not pushy or rude! If I don't respond within 48 hours I probably missed your message, or I saw your message and forgot to respond, so I will appreciate your reminder.*
  *****When you e-mail me, please put "SOC170-30x" and discussion section number in the subject lines.**
  Ex. [SOC170-301] Questions about next class

- **Office Hours:** If you have questions or concerns about course material, section, or exams please visit me during office hours. Please email me beforehand so I know to expect you. If you are unable to attend my regularly scheduled office hours, we can schedule an appointment via email.